

Are You a Salt Water Well?

Hebrews 4 shows that the agent that brings us into the rest of God is His Word. Israel fell short through unbelief, and we are warned not to fall after the same example. Therefore we labor to enter into rest, because:

The word of God is quick, and powerful, and sharper than any twoedged sword... and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart.

The Word of God is the only qualified agent to divide spirit from soul so cleanly that I can walk between the two halves and understand which one I am operating from.

The devil works against the emotions of the soul and builds strongholds to control us. The Word is the only qualified agent to discern those strongholds and empower us to pull down what is not of God and construct what is.

If the Word says I am healed, then I choose that as the standard. It does not matter how many preachers say healing has passed away, how many doctors say I will die, or how many well-meaning believers agree with them. The only standard I trust to discern between soul and spirit is the Word of God.

When storms come, the house built on the rock of doing His sayings will still be standing. The emotional voices may clamor that I am going to die, but I brace myself against that storm and choose one standard: His Word.

There are several ways to pull down what is incorrect and build what is right.

First is meditation in the Word: reading, memorization, and steady meditation. But it does not truly become meditation until the Holy Ghost gets involved.

Worship is another way. As you worship God for the truth of His Word, transformation begins through that Word.

Another powerful way is praying in the Holy Ghost. Proverbs says:

The spirit of man is the candle of the Lord, searching all the inward parts of the belly.

God lights the candle of your spirit and searches the dark places. Praying in the Holy Ghost is part of that searching process. It turns Him loose to illuminate you with spiritual understanding, revelation knowledge, and the flows of the Spirit.

The carnal mind cannot understand God because it is limited to what it can see and reason. God is discerned spiritually. The Holy Ghost teaches the part of you that can understand God.

Praying in the Holy Ghost edifies me. It builds me up so I can discern the thoughts and intents of the heart, pull down what is incorrect, and build what is of God.

James 3 begins:

My brethren, be not many masters, knowing that we shall receive the greater condemnation. For in many things we offend all. If any man offend not in word, the same is a perfect man...

The word "masters" means teachers, or those who have mastered something enough to teach it.

James says a bit turns a horse, and a small helm turns a great ship even in fierce winds. Then he says:

Even so the tongue is a little member, and boasteth great things. Behold, how great a matter a little fire kindleth!

And the tongue is a fire, a world of iniquity...

Every kind of beast has been tamed by mankind, but the tongue can no man tame by natural means. Without God's intervention, the tongue remains an unruly evil, full of deadly poison.

With the tongue we bless God, and with it we curse men made after His likeness. James says these things ought not to be.

James asks:

Doth a fountain send forth at the same place sweet water and bitter?

Can the fig tree, my brethren, bear olive berries? either a vine, figs?

So can no fountain both yield salt water and fresh.

At first this seems like a contradiction. James says people bless God and curse men with the same tongue, but then says no fountain can produce both salt and fresh water.

If God says no fountain can produce both, then it cannot. The question is not whether the Word is true. The question is whether we understand what He is saying.

When a person curses men and then blesses God, the issue is not that sweet and bitter water are truly flowing from the same fountain. The issue is that what is really in the fountain will eventually come forward. If the heart is a salt water well, even the religious speech is part of the deception.

Jesus said every tree is known by its own fruit.

A tree is a manufacturing company. It begins as a seed and passes through many hidden processes before fruit appears. Roots draw from the ground. Water flows like blood through the tree. Light and air are involved. Everything in the tree works toward the fruit it will eventually produce.

Whatever is working inside the tree eventually appears on the limbs.

So it is with us. Whatever stronghold dominates within will eventually appear outwardly. If the Word is transforming your life, that will appear. If a saltwater stronghold is operating, that will appear too.

You may cover it for a while, but eventually the real person steps forward.

Most of the time, when a salt water well comes into your presence and you do not know what it is, the bitter water is manifesting as deception. The person is painting a picture of what he wants you to believe he is.

That deception is already salt water. Later, when the true character appears, you may think sweet and bitter water came from the same fountain. It did not. The person was that way all along; the deception was part of the salt water.

In my gullible days, salt water wells shocked me repeatedly. Men could pet my ego, and I would think they were the greatest thing that ever came along. Then the true character would belch up, and I would be hurt. But the Holy Spirit had often warned me on the inside.

Without prayer, you will not have much discernment. You can be overpowered by the apparent majesty of someone's character and then crushed when the salt water finally floods your garden.

I understand people coming off drugs, abuse, and the world. They are babies desiring the sincere milk of the Word. They may go back and forth, lie, cover things, and still be in a genuine growth process.

That is different from people who have grown past that point and elected not to change their character. They know the language of religion. They know how Christians are supposed to act. You start a verse and they finish it. They look like everything you have been looking for in a believer.

What you cannot understand is why they left the last place they were.

When God began dealing with me on this, I began to understand salt water wells better. I also began to see the traces of salt water in myself.

One of the last areas God dealt with was not being absolutely truthful with people about my motivation. We like to appear a little bigger, more spiritual, and more noble than we are. We give excuses to cover weak areas of our lives.

Sometimes the truth is simply, "I did not want to go." But we dress it up with spiritual-sounding explanations. My wife has always been more direct. If someone asks, "Are you coming to my meeting?" she may simply say, "No." If they ask, "Are you busy?" she says, "No."

We are so used to people covering up that we hardly know what to do with plain truth.

The closer I can stay to being a sweet water well, the more I can represent truth as it is, rather than what I want people to believe about me.

But truth must be spoken in love. You do not walk up to someone and say, "That is certainly an ugly dress," just because you think it. That is not necessary truth-telling; it is foolishness.

If someone asks and you need to answer, you can do it without deception and without cruelty.

The issue is not blurting every opinion. The issue is whether the fountain is delivering truth or poison.

When James says the tongue is a world of iniquity, he means the tongue is the point that delivers what is in the world within.

A water fountain only delivers what is in the reservoir. If the reservoir has arsenic in it, the fountain poisons everyone who drinks.

That is why the tongue is powerful. It can turn a whole ship into a storm or out of one. It can direct the strength of a horse toward plowing or toward destruction.

The tongue cannot be tamed by natural means. It is tamed only by the new nature and the Word of God pulling down strongholds that are not of God and replacing them with the revelation knowledge of what is.

James says:

Be not many masters, knowing that we shall receive the greater condemnation.

A master is someone who has mastered a skill enough to teach it. In context, James is speaking to teachers, preachers, and believers who represent the kingdom.

If a person can master the tongue, James says he can bridle the whole body. That means teachers must first work on what operates within them. If the reservoir is poisoned, what they teach and present as life will poison others.

If bitter and sweet water cannot flow from the same fountain, then what is truly in the fountain will eventually come forward unless the fountain changes what is inside.

Every tree is known by its fruit. Given enough time, you will do what you truly want.

If you want to pray, you will pray. If you do not want to pray, you will not. If you want to be somewhere, you will be there. If you cannot be there but truly want to be, eventually you will change things so you can.

When people cover themselves with excuses, it is often because they know what they should be is better than what they are.

The first step is to come before God honestly.

James 4 asks where wars and fightings come from. They come from lusts in the flesh. A person in that condition may ask from God, but asks amiss, to consume it on his own lusts.

James says:

Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.

Draw nigh to God, and he will draw nigh to you.

Cleanse your hands, ye sinners; and purify your hearts, ye double minded.

To humble yourself in the sight of God is to become teachable before Him. It is not about performing humility in front of people. It is about treating people rightly because God sees.

Afflict yourself, mourn, and bring forth fruit worthy of repentance. Become sorry enough over the mess to turn. Resist the devil, and he will flee. God will lift you up, and the salt water well can become a sweet water well.

James says to cleanse your hands and purify your hearts. An impure heart is double-minded. A double-minded person is a salt water well.

Stop sinning, purify the heart, resist the devil, humble yourself in God's sight, and get rid of the salt water. Worship God. Pray in the Holy Ghost. Confess His Word. Say, "I will become what He says. I love people." Quit spewing salt.

Jesus said:

Blessed are the pure in heart: for they shall see God.

Purity of heart is the absence of deceit.

When Jesus saw Nathanael, He said:

Behold an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile!

Nathanael immediately said, "Thou art the Son of God." Why was that enough proof? Because no ordinary man could have known what truthfulness had cost Nathanael. Jesus saw the absence of guile in him, and Nathanael recognized the Son of God.

In God there is no darkness at all. In His immutability, He cannot change, be changed, or lie. That means He cannot add Himself to your lie, even when it comes out candy-coated as deceit.

The only reason a person lies is because he believes the temporary solution produced by the lie is better than the final solution God would bring if he told the truth. Or he wants to appear to be something he is not.

A person who lies, exaggerates, misleads, or hides the truth has no capacity to understand a person who will not lie, much less an infallible God who cannot.

Once you begin paying the price to be a freshwater well, it will cost you. If changing one dollar on your tax form would save you five thousand dollars but it is not truthful, the price is too high. Character assassination is more expensive than money.

Nathanael had paid a price to walk without guile. Jesus knew it. That is why He said Nathanael would see heaven open and angels ascending and descending.

Salt water wells can grow up. There is grace as long as a person is walking toward the Word.

But when someone uses the Word to scheme, cover up, manipulate, or capitalize on the love of God's people for personal gain, that person is in trouble. When the true character finally belches up, it is time to repent, not simply move to another group.

I pray that when such a person comes here, we will love him enough to sink an anchor into his jaw, not merely a hook. That is why we get people praying in the Holy Ghost. Before long, salt water and sweet water do not mix anymore.

We will stop there.